

one who will be living there, and you are the one who will be paying the mortgage. Your agent can help guide you toward homes that fit the parameters you have set up, but your agent should not be deciding what you want.

In order for your agent to help you transact on the right house, you will need a crystal-clear definition of what kind of purchase you are willing to make. Plus, the more you know in advance, the less likely you are to be distracted by a feature in an otherwise unsuitable home. (As much as we love smart lights and phone-charging stations, they probably aren't a top priority.)

You should consider the following:

What is the maximum price you're willing to pay for a home?

To help with this, take your price and run it through a mortgage calculator. This will give you an idea of the monthly payment you would be making on a home at that price. Make sure you also include home insurance, property taxes, and any extra fees like private mortgage insurance (PMI, which we'll explain in Chapter Six) when estimating your monthly cost.

How much house do you need?

Of course, you should know how many bedrooms and bathrooms you're looking for, and we strongly recommend having at least two toilets. (In addition to the obvious disadvantages, a home with only one bathroom is outdated—yes, even if the rest of the home is remodeled. Houses with two toilets sell faster and for more money than houses with only one.)

Also consider whether you need a home office, basement space, or garage space, and how big a yard you'll want, and make sure you're thinking five to seven years in the future. If you plan on expanding your family or currently have small children, take that into consideration. (Spoiler: They get so much bigger!)

Location, Location, Location...

Location is the one thing you can't change about your home. You probably know what city you want to live in, but are there other options nearby that may also work? Compare the resident amenities like recreation centers, city parks, and downtown features like shopping and restaurants. There may be